



Figure 1: InnerSource challenges

3. **Individual:** Inertia, fear, lack of awareness, and other such factors can make individual employees reluctant to adapt to an IS way of working and culture.

Addressing operational challenges

Final product vs incremental quality code

In a traditional organisation, the focus is more on the end output or product, whereas IS encourages frequent incremental additions to the code. The implementation of an IS program requires a “mindset shift from delivering [a] final product to incremental quality code” and can lead to a “culture shock and dissonance” (<https://www.blackducksoftware.com/resources/webinar/understanding-inner-source-fundamentals-transparency-collaboration-and-self-organization>). If not addressed at the right time, this shift can lead to demotivated employees and subsequently a failed IS implementation.

One way to deal with this shift is to divide the project/product into measurable incremental chunks and tie a performance metric (define specific KPIs) to each chunk.

Status oriented vs meritocratic (hierarchical vs egalitarian) culture

In status oriented culture, there is a rigid decision-making hierarchy. For example, the decision to add a module or functionality is decided by those higher in the hierarchy. Meritocracy,

on the other hand, involves decision making based on merit (of the decision) rather than a hierarchy.

Most corporate organisations have a status oriented culture. People strive to reach the next step on the hierarchical ladder. Meritocracies, on the other hand, are egalitarian. In a meritocracy, the importance of a thing depends only on the benefit to the overall project (its merit).

IS projects are egalitarian. Every contributor who is willing to help an IS project is welcome. Also, contributions to IS projects are judged based on the value they bring.

Such a transition from status oriented to a meritocratic culture with IS can result in conflicts. For instance, in IS all decision making happens in public and is based on consensus. This presents challenges for people who are accustomed to operating in a hierarchical environment where decisions come from above — from managers down to subordinates. This leads to hindrance in collaboration due to different priorities, and so on.

To mitigate this challenge, it is important to tie rewards and recognitions to the actions and contributions of the person rather than to ‘who’ or ‘what’ the person is. This will also help to remind teams about the egalitarian culture of IS and its decision-making process.

Users vs co-developers

Unlike open source, where users can be anywhere in the world, all the users of an IS software project are internal to the organisation it’s being developed in.

In a great IS implementation, users hold a very important position: they’re also the developers. Furthermore, they often don multiple hats like bug-fixer, tester, evangelist, and so on.

Attracting users to become active members of the community requires effort and can be a challenge because of reasons like:

- Users tend to use and not contribute back either due to laziness or they don’t see any incentive in doing so.
- People fix bugs only in their personal copy without contributing to the shared code.

To entice users to become contributors to the IS project, companies can organise a hackathon where the winner is the user with the best contribution. The core members of the IS project plus other relevant stakeholders can be the judges of the competition. The winners can be rewarded by elevating them to be contributors or a part of the core team for the project or program.

In addition, awards or recognitions for the one who fixes the most bugs can encourage users to take bug-fixing seriously.

Clear benefits vs vague advantages

Among the benefits of IS are rapid innovation, improved collaboration, increased code quality, faster time to market, more satisfied and motivated employees, and reduced attrition. We all know these are great advantages, but they’re also difficult to measure.

Peter Drucker famously said, “If you can’t measure it, you can’t manage it.” To effectively manage an IS program, organisations should set clear goals, define baseline metrics and KPIs, and engage in regular monitoring and course correction. These measures also help in assessing the efficacy of an IS program.

A few approaches to define the goals and measure them are:

- Employee satisfaction by surveys and personal connect with HR
- Attrition numbers and time-to-market through A/B testing
- Innovation through feedback from an expert jury

Such an approach to clearly define, measure, and track IS goals can go a long way in sustaining and thriving the IS efforts.